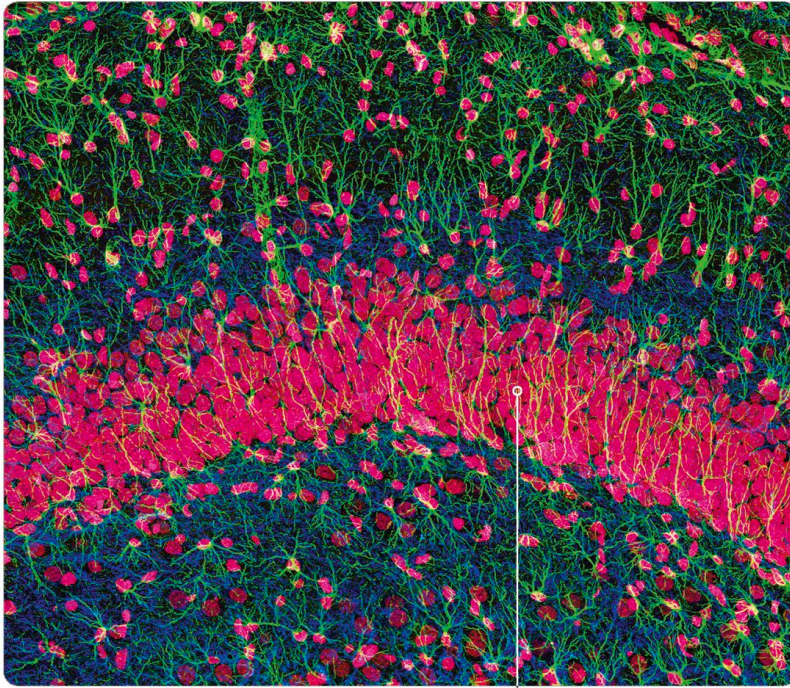


NEUROGENESIS

Scientists used to think that people are born with a certain number of nerve cells and that they cannot grow new ones. Research has since revealed that the growth of new neurons, or neurogenesis, can happen at any age. Neurogenesis occurs in key areas of the brain responsible for memory—the hippocampus—and smell. Neural stem cells in these regions of the brain develop new neurons.



SITE FOR NEW CELLS

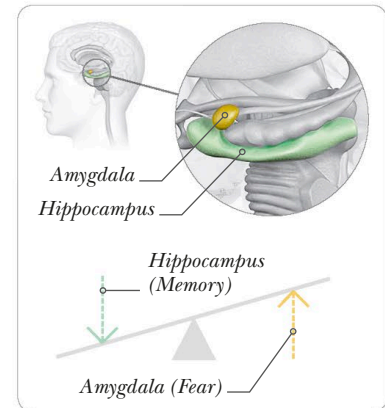
In this hippocampus tissue, helper cells or neuroglia are blue, axons are green, and neuron cell bodies and stem cells are pink.

Stem cells

Hippocampal stem cells can develop into new neurons, improving memory

CORTISOL LEVELS

Consistently high levels of the stress hormone cortisol are related to increased amygdala (fear center, see p.25) activity and decreased hippocampal (memory center) activity. When under these conditions, the hippocampus doesn't grow new neurons or connections well. Yoga practices are shown to reduce cortisol levels and reverse these effects, which may contribute to improving memory.

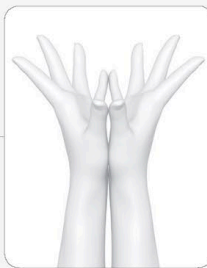


STRESS AND MEMORY

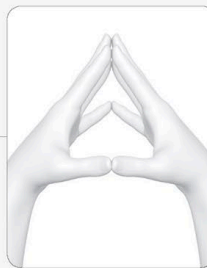
Increased activity in the amygdala is correlated with reduced activity in the hippocampus, which has an adverse effect on memory.

Practice hand mudras

Hand mudras are gestures that require concentration and awareness. Just as people who read braille have more developed hand-specific sensory areas of their brain, mudras may develop brain areas linked with sensory acuity, and fine motor skills.



PADMA MUDRA



HAKINI MUDRA



SHUNI MUDRA



BUDDHI MUDRA